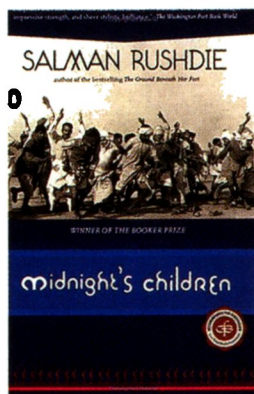


5 Rogue of Integrity Charandas

Thieves in India are often endearing characters. First staged in 1975 by playwright Habib Tanvir, *Charandas Chor's* protagonist too was no different. He was "a stock figure of fun, a lovable rogue taken from the folklore of Madhya Pradesh" (INDIA TODAY, October 1982). Charandas represented the common man who is capable of virtues rare in an unjust, class-based society—truthful and a man of his word. In Tanvir's version, his death makes him immortal in the minds of the people who revere him for his integrity. Charandas is considered India's Robin Hood, a man given to unlawful practices who maintains his integrity, because he has to honour the promises made to his guru. The play was later adapted by Shyam Benegal for a children's film.



6 A New Dawn Saleem Sinai

Saleem Sinai is a slightly unreal representative of post-colonial India, with his extraordinary nose and magic-realistic existence. But then he is responsible for a whole genre of literature that probably wouldn't have been read by the world if Salman Rushdie had not written *Midnight's Children* in 1981, which "exploded the myth of the Indian democratic system" (INDIA TODAY, April 1983).

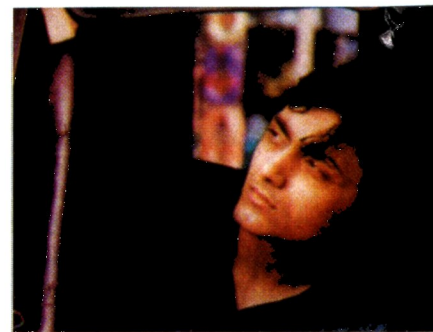
7 Ideal Idol Joseph James (J.J.)

Translated in over 15 languages, *J.J.: Some Jottings*, as titled in its English translation, is believed to be a watershed in Tamil post-Independence literature. This 1981 work by Sundara Ramasamy defied all notions prevalent in Tamil writing about the form and language of a novel. Wrestling with the pressing philosophical questions of its time, it provides insights into ideas, institutions and individuals, and the souring of idealism.



8 Nostalgic Charm Swami

"Low on melodrama and high on humour" (INDIA TODAY, August 1986), this collection of short stories by R.K. Narayan about Malgudi was symbolic of the 1980s subaltern India. *Malgudi Days's* 10-year-old Swami was like any other child growing up in the Doordarshan days, popularised by Shankar Nag's serial by the same name in 1987. On Saturday evenings, everyone wanted to be Swami.



9 A Novel Babu Agastya Sen

Every young man in the 1990s believed he was Agastya Sen, the protagonist of Upamanyu Chatterjee's novel *English, August* described as a "Tom Jonesian romp through babudom" by INDIA TODAY in August 1988. Sen is the dichotomy between urban and rural India. The Marcus Aurelius-reading IAS officer who finds himself dealing with the sleepy town of Madna continues to represent the antithesis of the yuppie, in short, the loser.

10 Sultry Affair Asha Rani

Shobhaa De's "bung-it-all-in novel", as INDIA TODAY called *Starry Nights* in July 1991, introduced us to a world we had only heard of in hushed whispers. Asha Rani, with its allusions to Rekha and her love affair with Amitabh Bachchan, scores as a memorable character, not in the least because she was bold and bitchy.

by Swagata Sen